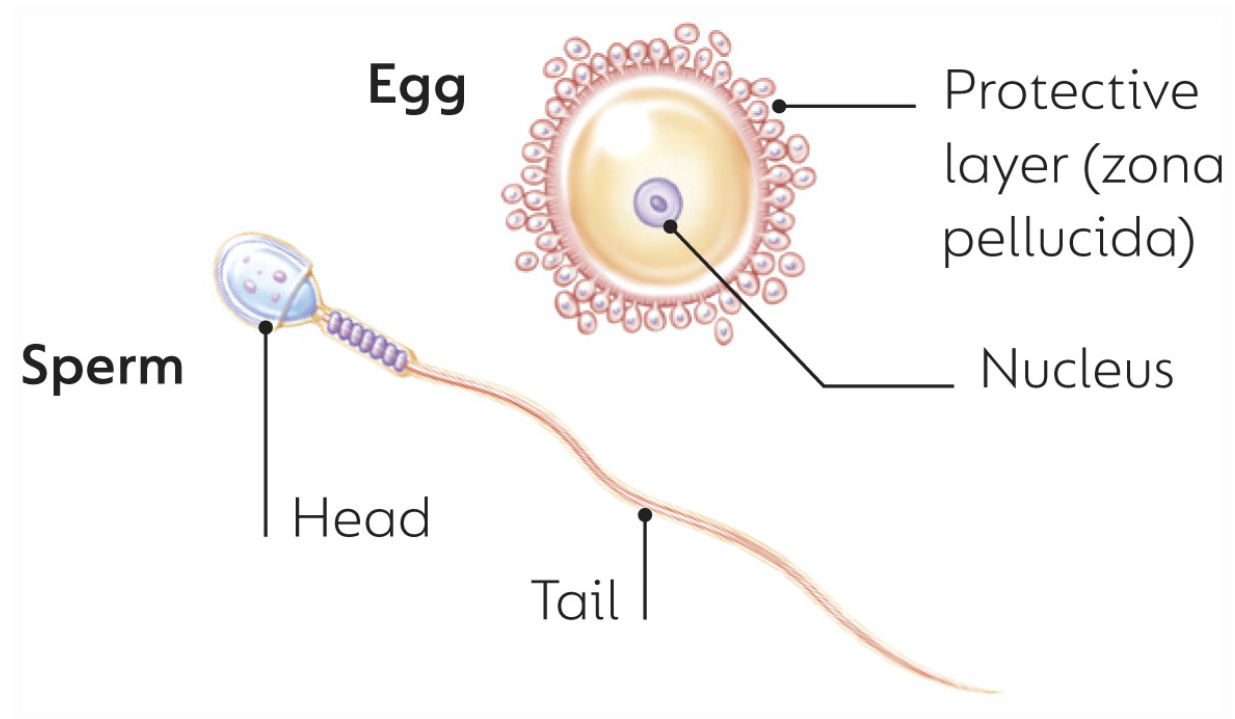


The moment of fertilization

Although many sperm cluster around the egg and try to penetrate its outer layer, only one of them will manage to burrow its way through the surface and fertilize the egg. Once this happens, the egg's outer layer thickens quickly to keep out other competing sperm, so that each egg can be fertilized by only one sperm.

THE EGG AND SPERM



The mature egg has a diameter of 0.1 mm and is surrounded by a protective outer layer known as the zona pellucida. The far smaller sperm consists of a head, which contains the male genetic material and enzymes to help break down the egg's outer layer, and a tail that propels the sperm up the vagina and uterus to the fallopian tube.

Implantation in the uterus

By the time the fertilized egg reaches the uterus, it has grown from a single cell into a compact cluster of cells, called a blastocyst. This cluster attaches to the uterine lining loosely, then more deeply and permanently.

At this early stage, the blob of cells, which is more than just a fertilized egg, but not quite an embryo, is sometimes referred to as a "conceptus." Although its sex is already determined, it's not remotely baby-shaped yet. The cells produce enzymes that allow it to digest its way into the uterus lining, and lie snugly below the surface.

Assisting conception

If you haven't become pregnant after a year of trying, your doctor may suggest tests and then you may be advised to embark on fertility treatment. The most popular is in vitro